Analysis of Television Commercials Based on Semiotics Theory：A Case Study from Maybelline New York's Campaign, "Limitless Lash Altitude" for Sky High Mascara

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1. Introduction：

In contemporary society, advertising effectively communicates a socio-cultural narrative that the brand desires to impart to consumers via the application of sensorial imagery and ideological connotation, contributing to the establishment and management of the brand identity. That is to say, advertising offers a brand-oriented story with allegorical meanings and profound ideological stances, as opposed to simply delivering random images without any meaning. Then, advertising furnishes audiences with a "magic system" that transcends material objects and ultimately enables people to evoke particularized memories of the brand while making purchases. By selecting the products, these audiences unintentionally position themselves as the main characters of the brand's narrative, thereby strengthening or constructing a personal identity by recognizing the brand's distinctive beliefs (Banet-Weiser, 2012b; Williams, 2014). According to Williamson (1978), in light of advertising's pervasive influence on people and society, it is crucial to comprehend its mechanisms of meaning production. This paper illustrates how advertisements communicate meanings and narratives using an example from Maybelline New York advertisement. In 2023, Maybelline partnered with Winnie Harlow, a famous fashion model and public spokesperson for vitiligo, and launched a "Limitless Lash Altitude" campaign for their mascara over New York City (McCann Worldgroup, 2023; L'Oréal, 2021).

This paper argues that Maybelline New York's "Limitless Lash Altitude" campaign, involving a female model participating in extreme anti-gravity aerial sports, creates a magical story of celebration of confidence, freedom, independence, uniqueness, and fearlessness to

young women while also appealing to girls' empowerment through the positivity of self-esteem and the challenge of stereotypical femininity.

The following paper is organized into three main sections. Firstly, this paper focuses on describing the narrative structure, cinematic aesthetics, and sound elements in this commercial. Following that, this paper will explore the underlying meaning behind the images in order to understand the story that the brand is trying to convey. Next, this paper will investigate the ideological mythology in advertising, which generates the brand story and connects with the viewer's identity on a sociocultural level.

2. Denotation of Advertisement Texts

Maybelline New York's 20-second television commercial "Limitless Lash Altitude" promotes Sky High mascara, which was released on January 9, 2023, with Winnie Harlow as the commercial's protagonist (L'Oréal, 2021; Maybelline New York Lash, n.d.). Based on Chandler's (1995) semiotic approach, in the first level of denotation, people need to pay attention to the images in the advertisement. As a result, the first part of this paper focuses on describing the narratives, aesthetics, and sound elements of the Maybelline New York mascara advertisement.

In the opening scene, the pink embossed packaging of the Sky High mascara and its accompanying brush swoop downward against the wind and resistance. Significantly, the image's diagonal composition elicits a feeling of tension, thereby directing the viewer's focus

toward the distinctively designed flex tower brush and the Maybelline mascara cream. Furthermore, a captivating female voice-over introduces that "Lash Sensational Sky High Mascara from Maybelline New York," while the upbeat rock music provides a harmonious accompaniment. Then, a woman who is able to effortlessly against gravity suddenly appears in the form of a superhero gesture. With a peaceful blue sky and the city of New York in the background, she wears a comfortable pink top, cargo pants, pink skydiving goggles, and gray heels. She carries her weight-bearing skydiving gear on her back, and her braided hair stands out against the high resistance of the sky. After that, the scene begins with a close-up of her eyes, in which she stares directly into the camera. This scene then shifts to a different angle of her, but she maintains her confident and queenly gaze. With her voiceover, the screen shows the slogan, "Limitless Lash Altitude." The camera selects a low-angle shot as soon as she finishes speaking to capture the instant she descends through the clouds while keeping her eyes fixed on the viewer. The medium close-up reveals a noticeable unevenness in the skin tone of her face, with white around her lips and tan elsewhere.

With a swift motion, she extends her arms for balance and seizes the mascara as soon as she notices it in the air, and her expression shifts from seriousness to joy and relief. Immediately after, the camera takes a close-up of the flex tower brush and cream, showing the brush's delicacy and the mascara cream's silky smoothness. The voice-over and on-screen slogan emphasize that lashes stretch from root to tip for limitless length and volume. Then, without hesitation, she opens her parachute and demonstrates the before and after of using mascara. Later, a low-angle shot brings the model and the sky-high parachute together in a frame. With a rapid landing, her eyes once again break down the barrier to meet the viewer directly and

seriously. Immediately after, the voiceover proclaims in an excited tone, "Lash Sensational Sky-High Mascara from Maybelline," and the model winks and smiles confidently for the camera. Finally, the camera pulls back to an extreme long shot of the female model standing on the roof of a tall building, thus showing her extraordinary strength and power.

3. Interpretation and Analysis of Meaning in an Advertising

According to Williamson (1978), the advertising strategy employs a method that aligns with the notion of currency. Through this approach, the advertiser subtly associates the meanings and values of the object with those of the commodity and the brand, making them interchangeable in terms of quality and values. In other words, the visual and auditory codes in the image form organic symbolic meanings, which allow the brand to construct a story. Maybelline New York's "Limitless Lash Altitude" campaign uses an unconventional image of a female model, anti-gravity skydiving, superhero-like body movement, New York skyscrapers, and non-diegetic soundtracks to celebrate confidence, freedom, independence, uniqueness, and fearlessness, which prompts a younger generation of women to instantly associate Maybelline mascara with a socio-cultural story of the brand at the time of purchase. They are not merely purchasing a problem-solving tool but also a way of life, a social trend, and a desire.

3.1 Visual Codes from a Female Model's Exterior

The female model on the screen has high cheekbones and a low nasal bridge, both of which deviate from the conventional standards of beauty. The female model's unconventional

appearance in the advertising symbolizes the uniqueness of everyone. In this situation, Maybelline is aiming for female customers who want to see a variety of female aesthetic inspirations on screen. Besides, in the close-up, the viewer can clearly see that the advertisement refuses to overly retouch and filter the model's face, instead retaining the skin's imperfections, demonstrating societal acceptance of appearance diversity rather than viewing the imperfections as inferiorities, emphasizing the Maybelline's call for women's confidence.

Moreover, the female model wears a pink tank top and cargo pants, which signify fitness, freedom, and a heroic attitude. The clean and sharp braided hair implies a straightforward personality, and the pointed-toe high heels signify a girl's development into a modern working woman with a successful profession, independence, self-confidence, and strength. Furthermore, the various earrings on her ears suggest a woman's free-spirited nature, indicating the bravery of a new generation of pioneers to stray from the standard and celebrate the quest for a unique style. In this respect, the brand grafts the underlying meaning of the visual codes onto the brand culture and the products to get consumers to buy them.

The bright and saturated pink colors on her face and body symbolize optimism, happiness, contentment, youth, and hope. The advertisers are committed to conveying a story of vitality, with the hope that when women use Maybelline mascara, they would feel a sense of excitement intermingled throughout their otherwise mundane lives. The pink color also carries the underlying meaning of comfort and healing. Maybelline wishes to convey the message that women's concerns and sensitivities about their looks can be healed and that Maybelline expects women to accept, affirm, and appreciate themselves.

3.2 The Codes of Body Movement and Gesture

The main visual element of the campaign is anti-gravity skydiving, which symbolizes overcoming barriers, freedom, breaking away from the routine, and being adventurous. As a result, the brand sends a positive message to the audience that they are capable of solving all types of problems and challenges calmly and that they deserve to be able to do what they love, even if it means taking risks. In this regard, Maybelline wants to inspire young women who have been lost in the workplace for a long time and make them feel energized after buying the products. In addition, the female model soars over the skies with the attitude of a world-saving Marvel superhero. The superhero symbolizes exceptional strength, extraordinary qualities, freedom from gravity, and inner development. In this respect, Maybelline presents the idea of a strong woman who is determined, independent, and free, leading viewers to believe that by purchasing Maybelline's Sky High mascara, they are the manifestations of a female superhero.

3.3 Setting and Sound Codes

The campaign presents Maybelline's magic system by placing the entire narrative over New York City, which implies aspirations, opportunities, youth, ambition, diversity, fashion, and limitless possibilities. As a result, Maybelline's promotion aims to introduce young ladies to a world of potential, implying that purchasing a Maybelline product is equivalent to purchasing success and confidence. Notably, the majestic skyline of New York City, USA, can be seen in the image. Skyscrapers symbolize limitless potential, broadening horizon, high social position, modernism, forward-thinking, intelligence, and innovation, and hence when

consumers buy Maybelline mascara, they feel as if they are in the jungle of a modern metropolis where dreams are realized.

The entire advertisement is supported by a magnetic female voiceover with a rhythmic tone, signifying a firm inner strength and confidence, which helps young ladies feel noble and confident about their lives when they purchase the goods. Meanwhile, the video incorporates metal rock background music with powerful drumming, reflecting the younger generation breaking away from tradition, adolescent rebellion, freedom, and release. This type of music also expresses young people's dissatisfaction with the status quo of life through inherent patterns, so the brand is targeted at the young female generation, encouraging them to be brave enough to break through the norms, free from the constraints of the world, and search for their inner true self.

4. Ideological Aspects of Maybelline Advertisement: Using Commodity Feminism

In today's society, branding has embraced and responded to ideological messages such as gender and race that are essential to people's daily lives, transforming the ideas of activism to the branding of activism. In the context of neoliberalism, the audience expresses support of social changes through personal purchases (Banet-Weiser, 2012a; Williamson, 1978). In other words, advertisements do not only sell products to viewers, but they also sell us a structure of meaning, as well as conveying deeper ideological messages that motivate consumers to make purchasing decisions for a sense of identity. This section claims that the Maybelline New

York advertisement approaches commodity feminism by emphasizing girls' empowerment in terms of the positivity of self-esteem and the challenge of conventional femininity.

4.1 Girls' Empowerment: The Positivity of Self-esteem

According to Arend (2014), stereotypical commercials always use unrealistic images of female celebrities and models to appeal to women's emotions, maintaining and reinforcing customers' preconceived notions of the perfect body shape and flawless skin, which elicits their feelings of deprivation and low self-esteem. As a result, the normative ideologies of patriarchy and capitalism have instilled in most women a chronic negative self-image and poor self-esteem. However, Maybelline's mascara advertisement subverts societal standardized measurements of beauty and promotes women's positivity of self-esteem.

Specifically, Maybelline's collaboration with Winnie Harlow, a model and prominent representative for vitiligo, exemplifies the disruption of conventional evaluations of women's attractiveness while emphasizing positive self-esteem. Harlow says in the interview that she is not embarrassed about having her skin noticed because she is proud of it. When others notice her, she opens her arms to display her unique markings in order to convey the message that all forms of beauty should be celebrated (Barlow, 2015). In other words, her skin and appearance stand apart from aesthetic homogenization, thus boosting young women's self-esteem. Maybelline hopes that consumers will select its products due to the supporting of women's empowerment. Additionally, Harlow's Jamaican heritage is mentioned in Barlow's (2015) interview with her. The purpose of the advertisement is to encourage women of all races, colors,

and cultures to recognize and exercise equal rights. Therefore, the advertisement expands a brand culture of female empowerment with a pluralistic flavor.

4.2 Girls' Empowerment: The Challenge to the Stereotypical Anticipation of Female Gender Roles

Extreme sports and women are rarely featured together in cosmetics promotion campaigns. However, in this ad, model Harlow takes on the challenge of skydiving, and at the end of the ad, she looks at the audience in a low angel shot and lands on top of a skyscraper with a pink parachute. Maybelline wishes to demonstrate, via the image of courageous women, that contemporary women resist convention. In addition to being submissive, obedient, and family and child-oriented, women can also be financially independent, strong, and determined. They have the courage to strive for purpose and make decisive decisions when they face a challenge or have a dream. Concurrently, the advertisement juxtaposes the concept of the masculine hero with the feminine model to demonstrate that women possess equal strength to men and are not obligated to be submissive to men; thus, it challenges traditional notions of women's roles. Notably, the female model maintains a constant gaze toward the camera, thereby embodying the gender myth of the look back in opposition to the masculine gaze. Her eyes seem to pass through the screen and establish an empowering connection with the viewer, which expresses a reversal of the gaze in a way that effectively critiques stereotyped female roles in traditional advertising and in real life.

5. Conclusion

First and foremost, this paper analyzes Maybelline New York's "Limitless Lash Altitude" campaign in terms of denotation, which includes exploring the narrative structure, camera technique, sound, and other elements in the advertisement. Next, this paper points out that Maybelline's advertisement tells a story about self-confidence, uniqueness, freedom, independence, and fearlessness through the use of the non-traditional image of a female model, superhero gesture, skydiving adventure, New York skyscrapers, and non-diegetic sound, providing the audience with the magic system.

Following that, this paper asserts that the "Limitless Lash Altitude" campaign draws on commodity feminism to portray an effort for women's empowerment, thus allowing women to contribute to feminist consciousness through buying. By working with vitiligo activists, the campaign shows the diversity of beauty and calls for women's healthy self-esteem. At the same time, the campaign builds an empowerment movement that subverts stereotypical gender roles through women's participation in extreme sports, the juxtaposition of the superhero and female model, and the reverse gaze.

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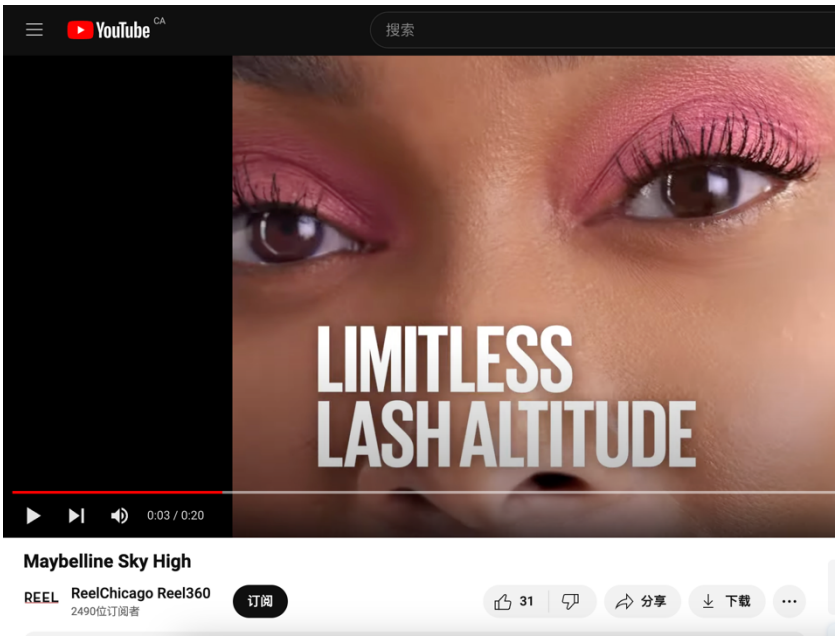
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